Zarb-e-Kaleem

Poetic English Translation

Allama Muhammad Iqbal

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Kalam 001: To the Readers

Source title: Nazreen Se(To Readers)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/nazreen-se-2/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

Until your gaze rests on life's realities,
Your glass cannot contend with stone.

This is the hour for the strength of hand and the telling blow;
In the field of war, do not seek the melody of the harp.

Life's capital is the blood of heart and liver;
Nature is a stream of blood, heedless one, not a stream of water.

Kalam 002: The Prologue

Source title: Tamheed(The Prologue)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/tamheed/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 9 stanzas, 18 nonblank lines

(1)

Neither in the temple nor the Sanctuary is the awakening of selfhood;
In the East, the spirit of nations lies narcotized.

If the world's tumult is not made easy for you,
The intoxication of celestial thoughts is a ruinous thing.

Your deliverance from the grief of death is not possible,
For you take the self to be a body of dust.

Time cannot conceal its own upheavals;
Your veil is the impurity of heart and sight.

To me was given the straw and refuse of Asia,
For my flame holds rebellion and fearlessness!

(2)

Your sin, Iqbal, is your gathering of assemblies,
Though you are, like the age, a thing of few joints.

To those poor ones who were used to the poppy,
Your song gave a taste for lofty passions.

Those broken-winged ones who were content in the courtyard
Now writhe for the blue expanses of the sky.

Your punishment is deprivation of the dawn's melody,
Deprivation of the station of longing, delight, and vision.

◆ Kalam 003: Islam and the Muslim: Dawn ◆

Source title: Islam Aur Mussalman–Subah(Dawn)

Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/islam-aur-musalman-subah/

Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 2 stanzas, 4 nonblank lines

This dawn, at times tomorrow, at times today,
No one knows from where it comes into being.

That dawn which makes existence's night-chamber tremble
Is born from the call to prayer of the believing servant.

◆ Kalam 004: There Is No God but Allah ◆

Source title: La Ilaha Illallah(NO GOD BUT ALLAH)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/la-ilaha-illallah/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 7 stanzas, 14 nonblank lines

The hidden secret of selfhood: there is no god but Allah;
Selfhood is a sword, a whetstone: there is no god but Allah.

This age is searching for its own Abraham;
The world is an idol-house: there is no god but Allah.

You have bartered away the wealth of pride;
The fraud of profit and loss: there is no god but Allah.

This wealth and worldly treasure, these ties and bonds:
Idols of doubt and fancy: there is no god but Allah.

The intellect has become the girdle of time and space;
There is neither time nor space: there is no god but Allah.

This song is bound neither to the season of rose nor tulip;
Whether spring or autumn: there is no god but Allah.

Though there are idols in the sleeves of the congregation,
I am commanded to give the call: there is no god but Allah.

Kalam 005: Submission to Fate

Source title: Tan-Ba-Taqdeer(Submission To Fate)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/tan-ba-taqdeer/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

In this very Quran is now the teaching of abandoning the world,
The teaching that made the believer lord of moon and Pleiades.

“Submission to fate” is now the manner of their deeds,
Those whose intentions once held God's decree concealed.

What was “unlovely” gradually became “lovely”;
In slavery, the conscience of nations is transformed.

Kalam 006: Ascension

Source title: MeerajAscension
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/miraj/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

Give him the rapture of longing, the delight of flight:
That atom can lay waste both moon and sun.

It is not difficult, friends of the garden, to enter the falcon's contest,
If the breath in the pheasant's breast is ablaze.

The Muslim is an arrow, and the Pleiades are his target;
The secret beneath the soul's pavilion is the point of Ascension.

You are the meaning of "By the star"—if you understood it, why be amazed?
Your ebb and flow still depends upon the moon.

Kalam 007: The Earth and the Sky

Source title: Zameen-o-Asman(The Earth And The Sky)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/zameen-o-asman/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

Perhaps what you call springtime,
In the eyes of others, is the season of autumn.

The chain of states changes with every moment;
O traveler on the path, do not fret over gain and loss.

Perhaps this earth belongs to another world,
While what you call the sky of your world is only earth!

◆ Kalam 008: The Decline of the Muslims ◆

Source title: Musalman Ka Zawal(The Decline Of The Muslims)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/musalman-ka-zawal/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

Though gold in this world can answer every need,
What poverty grants is not attained through wealth.

If the brave and bold youth of my nation arise,
My freedom of the dervish is no less than Alexander's empire.

The cause is something else, though you yourself suppose it:
The decline of the believing servant does not come from poverty.

If my essence has shone forth in the world,
It has shone through dervish freedom, not through wealth.

Kalam 009: Knowledge and Love

Source title: Ilm-o-Ishq(KNOWLEDGE AND LOVE)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/ilm-o-ishq/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 8 stanzas, 16 nonblank lines

Knowledge said to me, “Love is madness”;
Love said to me, “Knowledge is conjecture and surmise.”

Slave of conjecture and surmise, do not become a bookworm!
Love is all presence; knowledge is all veil!

The heat of love sets the universe's battle aflame;
Knowledge is the station of attributes, love the spectacle of the Essence.

Love is stillness and stability, love is life and death;
Knowledge gives birth to the question, love is the hidden answer!

Love works miracles in sovereignty, poverty, and faith;
Love's lowliest slaves possess crown and jewel.

Love is place and dweller, love is time and earth;
Love is sheer certainty, and certainty opens the gate!

In the law of love, the ease of reaching the destination is forbidden;
The storm's tumult is lawful, the pleasure of the shore forbidden.

Lightning upon love is lawful, attainment upon love forbidden;
Knowledge is the son of the Book, love is the Mother of the Book!

◆ Kalam 010: Independent Reasoning ◆

Source title: Ijtihaad
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/ijtihaad/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

Where in India can one learn the wisdom of faith?
Nowhere the delight of character, nowhere deep thought.

Where in the circle of longing is that courage of thought?
Alas, subjugation, imitation, and the decline of inquiry!

They do not change themselves; they change the Quran:
Woe, to what degree the jurists of the Sanctuary have become incapable!

This is the creed of these slaves: the Book is defective,
For it does not teach the believer the ways of slavery!

Kalam 011: Thanks and Complaint

Source title: Shukar-e-Shikayat(Thanks Cum Complaint)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/shukar-o-shikayat/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

I am a foolish servant, yet thanks be Yours;
I keep a hidden bond with the House of Lahut.

I gave the hearts a fresh fervor,
From Lahore to the soil of Bukhara and Samarqand.

Such is the effect of my breath that, in autumn,
The dawn-singing birds are joyful in my company.

Yet You created me in that land
Whose people are content with slavery!

◆ Kalam 012: Remembrance and Thought ◆

Source title: Zikr-e-Fikr(Dhikr And Fikr)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/zikar-o-fikar/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

These are all stations of one seeker's quest,
He in whose glory came, “He taught the names.”

The station of remembrance: the accomplishments of Rumi and Attar;
The station of thought: the treatises of Avicenna.

The station of thought is the measuring of time and space;
The station of remembrance is, “Glory be to my Lord, the Most High.”

◆ Kalam 013: The Mullah of the Sanctuary ◆

Source title: Mullah-e-Haram(Mullah Of The Mosque)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/mullah-e-haram/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 2 stanzas, 4 nonblank lines

It is no wonder that your reach extends to God;
From your gaze is hidden the station of man.

In your prayer remains grandeur, not beauty;
In your call to prayer there is no message of my dawn.

Kalam 014: Destiny

Source title: Taqdeer(Destiny)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/taqdeer/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

The unworthy sometimes receive power and might;
At times the world's own jewel is held in disgrace.

Perhaps some logic lies hidden within its action;
Destiny appears not subject to logic.

Yes, one truth is known to everyone,
Which the history of nations does not hide from us:

“At every moment Its gaze is upon the deeds of nations;
Its gaze is keen as the two-edged sword!”

Kalam 015: The Oneness of God

Source title: Touheed(ONENESS OF GOD)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/touheed/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 5 stanzas, 10 nonblank lines

Once this Oneness was a living power in the world;
What is it today? Merely a problem of scholastic theology.

If character's darkness is not lit by this radiance,
The station of the Muslim remains hidden from the Muslim himself.

I have seen, O commander, your army;
Its scabbards are empty of the sword of "Say: He is Allah."

Ah! Neither mullah nor jurist knows this secret:
Unity of thought without unity of character is incomplete.

What is a nation? What is the leadership of nations?
How should these poor two-rakat imams understand it?

◆ Kalam 016: Knowledge and Religion ◆

Source title: Ilm Aur Deen(Knowledge And Religion)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/ilm-aur-irfan/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

That knowledge, among its idols, is Abraham itself;
God has made it the companion of heart and sight.

One age, one life, one universe as well—
Proof of short-sightedness: the tale of new and old.

In the garden, the bud cannot be nurtured
If no dewdrop joins itself to the breeze.

That knowledge in which short sight is not entwined
With Moses' revelations and the sage's visions!

Kalam 017: The Indian Muslim

Source title: Hindi Musalman(Indian Muslim)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/hindi-musalman/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

The Brahmin calls him a traitor to his homeland;
The Englishman sees the Muslim as a beggar.

The law of Punjab's claimants to prophethood
Declares this ancient believer an infidel.

When, and from where, does the voice of Truth arise:
“A poor, forlorn one, left here amid this struggle!”

Kalam 018: On the Proclamation of the Freedom of the Sword

Source title: Azadi-e-Shamsheer Ke Alan Par(Written On The Occasion Of The British Government's Permission To Keep Sword)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/azadi-e-shamsheer-ke-alan-par/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

Have you ever pondered, O Muslim man,
What thing is the steel sword that rends the liver?

This is the opening line of that couplet in which
The secrets of Oneness come hidden onward.

I worry more over the couplet's second line:
May Allah grant you the sword of noble poverty.

If this sword too should come into the believer's grip,
He is either Khalid the valiant or Haidar the bold.

Kalam 019: Islam

Source title: Islam

Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/islam/

Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

The spirit of Islam is the light of selfhood, the fire of selfhood;
For life, the fire of selfhood is light and Presence.

This alone is the ordering of all things, this the root of manifestation;
Though nature has kept this spirit concealed.

If Europe takes offense at the word “Islam”, so be it:
Another name for this faith is “noble poverty”.

Kalam 020: Philosophy

Source title: Falsafa(Philosophy)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/falsafa/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 6 stanzas, 12 nonblank lines

Whether the thoughts of the young are hidden or manifest,
They are not concealed from the gaze of the Qalandar.

I know your condition, for I too
Passed long ago along this very road.

The wise do not entangle themselves in the twists of words;
The diver seeks the shell, not whether it holds a pearl!

That intellect is born only in the circle of the people of passion
Which can find the flame within the spark.

The subtle meaning the heart confirms
Is worth far more than a shining pearl.

Either dead or caught in death's final throes
Is any philosophy not written in heart's blood.

Kalam 021: God's Men

Source title: Mardan-e-Khuda(God's Men)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/mardan-e-khuda/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

He alone is a free man whose blow strikes home;
Not he whose every weapon is but trickery.

Since eternity, in the nature of the free, shoulder to shoulder stand
Qalandari, cloak-wearing, and cap-bearing.

Whom the age takes and makes a sun,
In their dust lies hidden that spark.

Their being is free from the circumambulation of idols;
These believers and infidels of yours are all idol-belt wearers.

Kalam 022: The Infidel and the Believer

Source title: Kafir-o-Momin(The Infidel And Believer)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/kafir-o-momin/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 3 stanzas, 6 nonblank lines

Yesterday, upon the riverbank, Khizr said to me:
"Are you seeking an antidote to the poison of the West?"

I have a point, sharp as a sword,
Cutting, polished, radiant, and flashing.

This is the infidel's mark: he is lost in the horizons;
This is the believer's mark: the horizons are lost within him.

Kalam 023: The True Guide

Source title: Mahdi-e-Barhaq(The True Guide)
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/mahdi-e-barhaq/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 8 nonblank lines

All are imprisoned in prisons they themselves have made,
Whether the fixed stars of the East or the planets of the West.

Whether church elders or sanctuary sheikhs,
There is neither freshness of speech nor freshness of deed.

The people of politics have the same old twists and turns;
The poet is trapped in this same poverty of imagination.

The world needs that true Mahdi,
Whose gaze would be an earthquake in the world of thought.

Kalam 024: The Believer

Source title: Momin(Believer)

Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/momin/

Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 4 stanzas, 10 nonblank lines including section markers; 8 poetic lines

(In the world)

With friends, he is soft as silk;
When truth and falsehood clash, the believer is steel.

His contest is with the heavens;
Earth-born, yet the believer is free from earth.

Sparrows and doves do not satisfy his gaze;
The believer is hunter of Gabriel and Israfil.

(In Paradise)

The angels say: the believer is heart-winning;
The houris complain: the believer does not mingle much.

Kalam 025: The Muslim Man

Source title: ہر لحظہ ہے مومن کی نئی شان، نئی آن(Mard-e-Musalman)Har Lehza Hai Momin Ki Nayi Shan, Nayi Aan
Source URL: https://allamaiqbal.org/zarb-e-kaleem/mard-e-musalman/
Source trace: JSON *urdu* and *transliteration*; 8 stanzas, 16 nonblank lines

Every moment the believer bears a new glory, a new splendor,
In speech, in deed, Allah's proof.

Wrath, forgiveness, holiness, and might:
When these four elements unite, a Muslim is formed.

Neighbor to Gabriel the Trustworthy, an earth-born bondsman:
His dwelling is neither Bukhara nor Badakhshan.

No one knows this secret: the believer
Appears a reciter, but in truth is the Quran.

The measure of nature's purposes is his resolve;
A balance in this world, a balance in the Hereafter.

The dew that cools the tulip's heart;
The storm that makes rivers' hearts tremble.

Nature's eternal song is his days and nights,
In its melody unique as Surah al-Rahman.

In my workshop of thought, stars are made;
Take up the star of your destiny and know it.